

EARLY MODERN WORKSHOP: Jewish History Resources

Volume 16: Senses and Perceptions

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God as Qualia: The Divinity of Sense Experience in Early Hasidism

Elly Moseson, University of Hamburg

A fundamental tenet of Hasidic ideology is the omnipresence of God. The idea that God is immanent in all things and can be found in all situations is repeatedly stressed in Hasidic literature. This belief was often justified on the basis of Kabbalistic theories of creation, which maintained that God emanated the substance of the universe from His essence. On the basis of this view of the nature of reality, there developed in Hasidism the imperative to recognize the presence of God not only at sacred moments but everywhere and in everything. This, in turn, led to an increased focus on mundane activities and bodily experiences as possible loci of divine revelation.

While these ideas are ubiquitous in Hasidic literature they are rarely treated systematically. The preferred mode of discourse in Hasidism was the sermon in which classical texts were expounded through traditional forms of hermeneutics. Furthermore, the primary goal of these sermons was to promote a certain kind of praxis while its theoretical justification was generally of secondary concern. Finally, the originality, complexity and subtlety of some of the notions developed in Hasidic literature along with the lack of a terminology sophisticated enough to express them may have contributed to the rather confused form they often took.

The texts presented here are striking in both their form and their content. In addition to being relatively theoretical and expository they promote an original understanding of the divine nature of subjective experience and of sense experience in particular. According to these texts, when we perceive an object we perceive only its perceptual qualities, which are given to us in subjective experience. Since such qualia (the qualitative character of sensations) are not themselves material they must perforce be spiritual, or, in other words, they must be divine. By differentiating the materiality of the object, which is its external form, from one's subjective experience of its qualities, which is its true spiritual essence, one can come to recognize it as a manifestation of God's divinity. Conversely, the lack of awareness of God's presence in the world is merely the consequence of a mistaken understanding of the nature of our own perceptual experience.

Although this theory is not limited to sense perception but embraces all subjective experience, including intellective and affective states, the explicit focus on sensation reflects a view of the divinity of experience, as such. As a positive view of subjective experience, the theory further offers important insight into the Hasidic understanding of the body and bodily experience more generally. The soul does not merely inhabit the body but permeates it in all of its aspects, including what is perhaps its most corporeal—sense experience.

The first text is the “Second Introduction” to *Magid devarav le-ya’akov* (Koretz, 1781) containing a collection of discourses attributed to the Hasidic figure Dov Ber, the Maggid of Mezritsh (d.1772). This introduction, written by the Maggid’s disciple Solomon of Lutzk (who also published the collection), is presented as “the key to the book.” As a collection of sermons, the book itself lacked any sustained discussions of its theoretical framework and so Solomon decided to compose an introduction in the form of an essay delineating what he took to be the essence of the worldview that the Maggid assumed throughout his sermons. What is particularly striking about this text, is the appeal to sense experience in support of the idea that God is present in all things.

The second text is a complementary discussion of the same topic found in Solomon of Lutzk’s own collection of sermons *Dibrat shelomo* (Żółkiew, 1848). It is a relatively theoretical passage excerpt from a longer more hermeneutical sermon. Even more so than in his introduction to *Magid devarav le-ya’akov*, Solomon here focuses on the divinity of sense experience in particular. The passage also contains a first-person account of an interaction he had with someone who came to him for spiritual advice, a relative rarity in Hasidic literature.

The third text is a discourse found in another collection of sermons attributed to the Maggid, *Or torah* (Koretz, 1804). The actual author of the passage remains unknown, however, and it contains a number of features that distinguish it from most of the other discourses in this and related collections. Although it is in the form of rather dense and arcane interpretations of a series of biblical texts it presents the idea of the divinity of subjective experience in the rather unusual form of deductive propositions amounting to a kind of sorites polysyllogism. Here, as in the previous texts, the material object in itself is differentiated from its qualia, which is viewed as divine. Particularly interesting is the fundamental role given to the experience of desire as the connecting factor between sense experience and the apprehension of spiritual reality.

The fourth text is another anonymous discourse found in a further collection of sermons attributed to the Maggid, *Likutim yekarim* (Lemberg, 1792). Here we find

a description of a very practical application of some of the theoretical ideas found in the other texts—consuming alcohol as a means of heightening one's emotions during worship. The use of food and drink to induce religious enthusiasm was widespread in the early Hasidic movement and, as the “witticism” with which the passage concludes suggests, the popularization of such practices was treated with a measure of ambivalence within the movement, even if they were still upheld in principle.

The presentation will discuss the originality of the view of sense experience found in these texts, their origins, and their social and historical impact. It will also address the question of the relationship between the appearance of such new attitudes toward the body and bodily experience and the emergence of modernity. Finally, it will explore the difficulties faced by the authors of these texts in speaking about these topics using traditional modes of discourse as well as the challenge of relating such modes of discourse to contemporary ways of construing subjectivity.

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Solomon of Lutzk, *Magid devarav le-ya'akov* (Koretz, 1781), Second Introduction (unpaginated)

The Second Introduction and the Key to the Book

Here I venture to speak/ and muster my strength/ I have seen fit to preface/ words of love, set in sockets of fine gold, none other than the words of our master, teacher and rabbi the author/ the precious words I received from him/ for beloved friends, the Jewish people/ who cleave to and are united with God and His Torah/ as a key to this pure and holy work, to open various closed discourses/ so that it not be like a sealed book/ locked and shut up/ to those who have not gone in and gone out/ the voice of my believed knocks/ as they said in the *Zohar* (II, 14a) “R. Simeon said [to R.] Eleazar his son: [‘Arise and] pass thy hand over his mouth, [for he did not know of such,] for he is not accustomed to it’”/to quench their thirst/so they might understand, with the application of their intellects and attention/the first fruits of their strength.

First of all, one ought to know that "the whole earth is full of His glory" (Isa. 6:3) and "there is no place empty of Him" (*Tikunei zohar*, 123b) and He is within [all] worlds, etcetera (cf. *Atkinu se'udata* and *Zohar* III, 224a). That the vitality of the Creator, blessed be He, is everywhere can be observed empirically (*nireh be-hush*) in every object. For a given object will certainly have some taste or smell or appearance or love—that is, it will be something beloved, or else something dreadful or beautiful or possess some other similar attribute. And if we divest it of its materiality and consider solely its spirituality such as its taste or smell or one of its other above mentioned [attributes] in themselves, it will certainly be observed empirically that it is something that cannot be sensed (*murgash*) with hands or eyes of flesh but is rather something sensed in an apprehension (*nirgash be-hasagah*) by the person's vitality and soul alone. It must therefore certainly be something spiritual, the vitality of the Creator, blessed be He, which inheres in this material object like a soul in a body. It is similarly so with all objects and all movements as it is written in the book *Hovot ha-levavot* (2:5) "all your movements are tied to the will of the Creator." There are in all of them sparks of vitality drawn from the

Creator, blessed be He, who is “the bundle of life” (I Samuel, 25:29), “the light of life” (Job 33:30; Ps. 56:14), “the fountain of life” (Ps. 36:10) and “the life of life” (*Tikunei zohar*, 116a) and from Him is vitality drawn down into all things from the highest rungs to those below. This is [the meaning of] the constriction (*tzimtzum*) of His blessed presence, which dwells among those below. And each spark derives from its own particular world. For example, [in the case of] an object of love, the love within it originates in the [divine] world of love. That is, there must certainly be a source and root from where the love for any object of love originates.

In order to make the nature of this root a little more comprehensible let us consider [as an example] the spirituality of the root of love itself, as mentioned. We observe empirically that it is nothing but the vitality of the Creator, blessed be He, that has been constricted, as it were, so that it might be apprehended in the aspect of love. However, there is certainly vitality and spirituality that is apprehended not in the aspect of love but rather in some other aspect, such as the aspect of fear or beauty or one of the other attributes. They are all certainly vitality and spirituality as mentioned, but each one is apprehended differently than the others for they were constricted in a different constriction, that is, into a different apprehension. In their essential inwardness, however, they are all identical for they are vitality and spirituality, as mentioned—they all originate in a single root within which there are no distinctions at all.

And this is what is stated in the *Tikunei zohar* (99b; cf. *Zohar* I, 91a) “And in her do all supernal images appear”—that is, [this occurs] by means of the constriction [into specific] apprehensions. [Each of these attributes] is in the aspect of the feminine in relation to what is above, for it receives from the root of roots. And the enlightened will understand. This is why they are called worlds (*olamot*)—the vitality of the Creator is hidden (*mitalem*) and constricted in particular apprehensions. They are also called attributes (*midot*) because they are estimated and apprehended in a particular measure and quantity (*midah*) and not in another. In truth, however, each [attribute] includes all of the others for the beginning of the drawing down from the root of roots was for the sake of His blessed kindness (*hasdo*) to benefit His creatures and He needed to constrict (*le-tzamtzem*) and draw down to the [given] attribute [vitality in a limited form] like a line and a spark. And this is the vitality and splendor (*ve-hitpa’arut*) of the Creator, as it were. This is in accordance with [the verse] (Gen. 2:7) “And he blew into his nostrils” the spirit of life—[about which it is commented] “All who blow, blow from their essence” (*Shefa tal*, Introduction; cf. *Sefer ha-peli’ah*, 8b). It was possible for [the vitality] to keep being drawn down infinitely—in accordance with [the verse] (Deut. 5:18) “with a great voice, and it went on no more” (read alternatively as “that did not

cease”)— but since this was not [God’s] intention He needed to overcome (*le-natze’ah*) [this tendency] so that His blessed glory (*hodo*) could be revealed and it could be connected (*me-kushar*) to this given attribute (*midah*) and apprehension. These matters are very profound and require extensive explanation as to how it is in each world—“for one higher than the high watcheth [and there are higher than they]” (Eccles. 5:7)—but I am here being brief [and aim] only to stir the ear to hear while studying this holy work.

To return to our topic, there is nothing that lacks a root above, as mentioned. This is why the holy tongue contains the infinitive (*makor*), the active verb (*po’al*) and the passive verb (*nifal*). The infinitive corresponds to the root of the thing, as mentioned; the active verb corresponds to the acting person who draws down from the above-mentioned source (*makor*) and root; and the passive verb corresponds to the thing that is drawn down from that source and root. Take, for example, joy (*simhah*). There is the [supernal] world of joy, as mentioned—that is, the vitality of the blessed Creator that is apprehended in the [form of] the attribute of joy. This is the source (*makor*). The person who is joyful actualizes (*po’al*) and draws down upon himself [joy] from the above-mentioned world of joy at a specific moment before which he had not been joyful. And the person’s experience of joy itself is the actualized (*nifal*) [joy], as mentioned. Thus, although all a person sees [of an object] is the spark, which to the eyes of flesh appears to be small, if he is sensible and intelligent and divests it of the materiality within which it is clothed and imagines in his mind that it is nothing but divine vitality taken from the supernal source, as mentioned, the light and vitality [of the object] will become infinitely large and mighty—for in its spirituality and vitality it is connected to its source. And in each thing he will see its supernal root and source. One can perhaps say that this is the meaning of the verse (Isa. 61:10) “I will greatly rejoice (*sos asus*, lit. ‘rejoice I will rejoice’) in the Lord.” That is, [the word] “rejoice” (*sos*) is the source (*makor*) [while] the meaning of “I will rejoice (*asus*) in the Lord” is that when I will rejoice in the Lord and be alert and recall that [the joy] is a holy spark from God then I will certainly be connected to the source, that is, the above mentioned [word] “rejoice” (*sos*). And this is also the meaning of [the verse] (Deut. 15:10) “Thou shalt surely give [him], and thy heart shall not be grieved [when thou givest unto him].” That is, when you give and you understand that through this giving the source of the giving of charity is awakened then certainly “thy heart shall not be grieved.” And the enlightened will understand. This is the manner in which a person should constantly consider his own attributes, whether love, fear or one of the other attributes, as well as his speech and voice and

thought. He should recognize that they are vitality and spirituality and each one of them certainly derives from its supernal root and source—that is, the root of love from which [love] is drawn down to all creatures and all objects of love and similarly the root of fear and that of the other attributes, as well as the root of the world of speech from which speech is drawn down to all speaking [beings] and to all other creatures as well, for they all contain utterances of the Holy One, blessed be He. His blessed vitality is like the [undifferentiated] voice, while the garments within which the vitality has been constricted are like speech, which clothes and constricts the voice. And the enlightened will understand. And this is [the meaning of the verse] (Ps. 33:6) “By the word of the Lord were the heavens made, etcetera.” And there is similarly a root of the world of thought, as mentioned.

When he considers and recognize this, there will fall upon him very great fear and shame before God, Who accompanies him in all his movements, as it is written in *Hovot ha-levavot* (3:5), “Do not rebel against your master when he sees you”—for how can one [use] His blessed power and vitality to act against His will? And he will constantly be attached to God with a marvelous attachment. And through worship and attachment to the Creator, blessed be His name, one is able to elevate all the worlds, as is known. Since every one of his attributes as well as his speech and his thought will be attached to the roots from where they are drawn down to all creatures, all creatures will certainly be attached to him, while he himself will be attached to the Creator, blessed be His name. And this is [the meaning of the Talmudic dictum] (B. Hag. 12b) “The world rests on one pillar and a righteous person is its name.”

One can perhaps say that this is the meaning of the Mishnah (M. Ber. 9:5) “‘With all your might’ (Deut. 6:5)—with each and every measure he metes out to you, thank Him very much.” The difficulty [addressed by the Mishnah] was that since [the verse] should have been written [with the word] “might” (*me’od*) what then is [the significance of writing] with all your might (*be-khol me’odekha*)? This implies that there are various kinds of “might.” [The Mishnah] therefore explained it [as referring to] “each [and every] measure, etcetera.” That is, the attributes of man appear to be very small, as mentioned, but when [people] worship God, blessed be He, and attach themselves to Him and discern in their minds and thoughts how each one [of their attributes] is attached to its root, as mentioned, then each one becomes exceedingly large. This is [the meaning of] “with each [and every] measure he metes out to you, thank Him very much”—that is, when you “thank him” with attachment, as mentioned, then each one [of the attributes] will be “very

much.” [If you] remember this principle and do not forget it, “then shalt thou walk [in thy way] securely, [and thou shalt not dash] thy foot (Prov. 3:23) in this pure and holy work. And the good Lord “will withhold no good thing from them that walk uprightly” (Ps. 84:12). Amen, Selah.

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ר' שלמה מלויצק, מגיד דבריו ליעקב (קארעץ, תקמ"א), הקדמה שניה

הקדמה שניה ומפתח הספר

והנה נא הואלתי לדבר. וחיילים אגבר. ראיתי להקדים. דברי דודים על אדני פז ה"ה דברי אדומ"ו בעה"מ מיוסדים. כפי אשר קבלתי ממנו דבריו הנחמדים. לרעים ואהובים המה היהודים. אשר בד' ובתורתו דבקי' ואחודים. להיות לחיבור הטהור והקדוש הזה כמפתח וכמה מאמרים סתומים יפתח. ולא יהי' כספר החתום. נעול וסתום. למאן דלא עייל ונפיק. קול דודי דופק. כמאמרם ז"ל בזהר (זוה"ק ח"ב יד, א) אר"ש אלעזר ברי אעבר ידך פומוי דלא רגיל בהאי. לרוות צמאונם. להבין בשים שכלם ועיונם. ראשית אונם.

תחלת הכל ראוי לדעת שמכה"כ ולית אתר פנוי מיני' והוא בתוך עלמין וכו' ודבר זה נראה בחוש בכל דבר כי בכ"מ יש חיות הבורא ב"ה כי בוודאי יהי' בדבר ההוא טעם או ריח או מראה או אהבה ר"ל שהוא דבר נאהב או דבר נורא או דבר מפוא' וכן שארי מדות וכאשר נפשיט אותה מן הגשמיות ונחשוב רק רוחניות לבד כגון הטעם או הריח וכיוצא בו כנ"ל בעצמו בוודאי נראה בחוש שהוא דבר הבלתי מורגש בידים ועיני בשר רק שהוא נרגש בהשגה לחיות ונשמת אדם לבד א"כ בוודאי הוא דבר רוחני וחיות הבורא ית' השוכן בדבר המוגשם הזה כנשמה בגוף וכן הוא בכל דבר ובכל תנועה כמ"ש בח"ה כי כל תנועותיך נקשרת בחפץ הבורא ע"כ. ובכולם הם נצוצי חיות נמשכין מהבורא ית' שהוא צרו"ר החיים ואו"ר החיים ומקו"ר החיים וח"י החיים וממנו ית' נמשך חיות בכל דבר מרום המעלות עד למטה בתחתונים וזהו צמצום שכינתו ית' ששוכן בתחתונים. וכל ניצוץ הוא נלקח מעולם שלו ד"מ דבר של אהבה האהבה שבו הוא נלקח מעולם האהבה ר"ל שבוודאי יש מקור ושורש שממנו נלקח אהבה לכל דבר שיש בו אהבה

ונאמר לקרב אל השכל קצת מהות השורש נחשוב ברוחניות שורש האהבה עצמה כנ"ל נראה בחוש שהוא רק חיות הבורא ית' שנתצמצם כ"י שיהי' מושג בבחי' אהבה כי בוודאי יש חיות ורוחניות שאינו מושג בבחי' אהב' רק בבחי' אחרת כגון בבחי' יראה או התפארות ושארי מדות כי בודאי כולם הם חיות ורוחניות כנ"ל רק שכ"א אינו מושג כמו חבירו כי נתצמצם בצמצום אחר ר"ל בהשגה אחרת אבל בפנימיותם העצמית כולם שווים שהם חיות ורוחניות כנ"ל כי כולם נמשכים משורש א' אשר שם אין שום התחלקות כלל

וז"ש בת"ז ובה מתחזיין כל דיוקנין עילאין פי' ע"י צמצום ההשג' הנ"ל כי היא בחי' נוק' לגבי' דלעילא שמקבלת מן שורש השרשים והמ"י. לזה נקראים עולמות ר"ל שחיות הבורא הוא מתעלם ונתצמצ' בהשגה זו וג"כ נק' מדות ע"ש שהם משוערי' ומושגים בשיעור ומדה זו ולא באחרת ובאמת כ"א כלולה מכולם כי תחלת ההמשכה משורש"ש השרשי"ם הי' למען חסד"ו ית' להטיב לברואים והוצרך כ"י לצמצ"ם ולהמשיך למדה זו רק כמין קו וניצוץ [ו] והוא החיות והתפא' רות הבורא כ"י ע"ד ויפח

באפיו כל הנופח מעצמותו הוא נופח ר"ח חיים רק שהי' באפשרי להמשך עד בלי די ע"ד קול גדול ולא יספ אשר אין זה המכוון והוצרך לנצ"ח שיתגלה הו"דו ית' ושיהי' מקו"שר במ"דה והשגה זו הגם שהדברים עמוקים מאוד וצריכים ביאור רחב איך הוא בכל עול' כי גבוה מעל גבו' שומר אמנם כן באתי בקצרה רק להעיר אופן לשמוע בלימוד החיב[ו]ר הקדוש הזה

נחזור לענייננו כי אין לך דבר שאין לו שורש למעלה כנ"ל וזהו שיש בלשון הקודש מקו"ר ופוע"ל ונפע"ל ר"ל כי המקור הוא שורש הדבר כנ"ל ופועל ר"ל האדם הפועל הוא ממשיך מן המקור ושורש הנ"ל ונפעל הוא הדבר שנמשך מן המקור ושורש הנ"ל ד"מ שמחה יש עולם השמחה כנ"ל ר"ל חיות הבורא ית' הנישוג במדת השמחה והוא המקור והאדם השמח הוא פועל וממשיך עליו מעולם השמחה הנ"ל בעת הזאת כי מקודם לא הי' שמח והשמחה עצמה של האדם הוא הנפעל כנ"ל. נמצא כשהאדם הוא נלבב ועיני שכל לו הגם שהניצוץ שרואה לפי הנראה בעיני בשר הוא קטן הכמות אמנם כשיפשיט אותה מן הגשמיות [ה]מלוכש בתוכה ויציר בשכלו שהו[א] רק חיות אלהיות הנלקח משורש העליון כנ"ל אזי בוודאי יהי' אורה וחיותה רב ועצום עד אין קץ כי ברוחניותה וחיותה היא דבוקה להמקור ויראה בכל דבר שורשה ומקורה העליון

וא"ל שז"פ הפסוק שוש אשיש בד' ר"ל שוש הוא מקור אשיש בד' ר"ל כשאשיש בד' ואהי' זריז ונזכר שהוא ניצוץ קדוש ממנו ית' אז בודאי אהי' דבוק בהמקור היינו שוש הנ"ל וזהו ג"כ פי' נתון נתן ואל ירע לבבך וכו' ר"ל כשתתן ותבין שע"י נתינה זו נתעורר מקור הנתינה של הצדקה ובוודאי אל ירע לבבך והמ"י.

וכן עד"ז יחשוב האדם תמיד במדותיו העצמיית הן מדת אהבה או יראה או שארי המדות וכן דיבורו וקולו ומחשבתו ויבחין שה' חיו' ורוחניו' ובוודאי כ"א נלקח משורשו ומקורו העליון ר"ל שורש האהבה שממנו נמשך לכל הברואי' ובכל דבר של אהבה וכן שורש היראה ושארי מדות וכן שורש עולם הדיבור שממנו נמשך דיבורים לכל המדבר' ולכל הנבראים כי בכולם יש דיבורים של הקב"ה כי החיות שלו ית' הוא כמו הקול והלבושים שנתצמצם שם החיות הוא כמו הדיבור המלביש ומצמצ' לקול והמ"י וזהו בדבר ד' שמים נעשו וכו' וכן יש שורש עולם המחשבה כנ"ל

וכשיחשוב כן ויבחין זאת בודאי יפול עליו יראה גדולה ובושה עד מאוד מלפניו ית' ש' השוכן אתו בכל תנועותיו כמ"ש בח"ה אל תמרה את אדוניך והוא רואה אותך כי איך יעשה בכוחו וחיותו ית' נגד רצונו ויהי' תמיד דבוק בו יתברך דביקות נפלא וידע כי בעבודתו ודבקותו להבורא יתברך שמו יכול להעלות כל העולמות כי מאחר שכל מדה שלו ודבורו ומחשבתו יהי' דבוק להשורש שממנו נמשך לכל הברואים בודאי יהיו כל הברואים דבקים אליו והוא יהי' דבוק להבורא יתברך שמו וזהו על עמוד א' העולם עומד וצדיק שמו.

וא"ל שזהו פי' המשנה בכל מאודך בכל מדה שמודד לך הוי מודה לו במאוד מאוד. דהוקשה לו רק היל"ל מאוד מהו בכל מאודך משמע דיש כמה מאוד לכך פי' בכל מדה וכו' רצה לומר דהנה מדותיו של אדם לפי הנראה דהם קטני הכמות כנ"ל אמנם כשעובדין בהם את השיב"ה ומדבקין א"ע אליו ית' ומבחינים בדעתם ובמחשבת' איך כ"א דבוקה בשרשה כנ"ל אזי כ"א גדול עד מאוד וזהו בכל מדה שמודד לך הוי מודה לו במאוד מאוד ר"ל כשתהי' מודה לו בדביקות כנ"ל אז יהי' כ"א במאוד מאוד וזכור כלל זה ואל תשכח אז תלך לבטח רגליך בחיבור הטהור והקדוש הזה וד' הטוב לא ימנע טוב להולכים בתמים א"ס.

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Solomon of Lutzk, *Dibrat shelomo* (Zolkiew, 1848), II, 15a

Prima facie, this world is that which is visible to the eye while the spiritual world and its delights are not visible at all. However, the truth is that what is primarily visible and perceptible is the spiritual delight (*ta'anug*). For that which is visible and perceptible is solely the appearance of things, and they all differ in color, whether white, red, green, etcetera. However, they do not differ in their material aspects, for the material is merely a vessel and delimiter that delimits the appearance and color that is in it. But it is nothing apart from the delight that is in it, which is its appearance and color. So, too, in the case of touch there are differences between soft and hard, hot and cold and all of these are spiritual things. Similarly, in the case of taste each thing has a different taste—the taste of one thing is not the same as that of another—and in the case of smell, as well, there are many different variations. The material aspect of each thing, however, is solely a vessel and delimiter that delimits the appearance and taste and smell while the spirituality is the vitality of the Creator, blessed be He, that is drawn down and delimited within this particular material object. And [this spirituality] is verily nothing other than the letters and words of the Holy One, blessed be He, for the letters are spiritual and sweet and tasty and fragrant as it is written (Ps. 19:11) “More to be desired are they than [gold, yea, than much fine gold] sweeter also than [honey and the honeycomb].” And our sages of blessed memory said (B. Shab. 88b) “With each [and every] commandment [that emerged from the mouth of the Holy One, blessed be He,] the entire world was filled with fragrant spices,” [referring to] what was mentioned. And they are also beautiful, for they are [nothing but] the luminosity of the Creator, blessed be He, and it is thus written (Num. 12:6) “I will make Myself known unto him in a vision.”

But if I were to try to explain this matter and to further clarify how and in what manner the letters and words are spiritual and beautiful, and contain all varieties of colors and smells and tastes, as I have understood and received but as a drop in the ocean from the mouth of my master, of blessed memory, the page would be too short to contain it. Even to put [these matters] into words and express them orally is difficult. As it is stated in the *Zohar* (I, 164a; cf. I, 194b) “To the point that he

was unable to speak.” For [understanding them] requires great diligence in serving wise scholars and the great ones of Israel, to listen to their words spoken in truth. One will then learn from [their words] to understand and comprehend, and to divest each thing from its material [form,] and to gaze only upon its spiritual [essence,] and to constantly have before one’s eyes the vitality and luminosity of the Creator, blessed be His name, and not see anything else besides this, as it is written (Ps. 16:8) “I have set the Lord always before me,” and as it is written (Deut. 4:35) “There is none else beside Him.”

And someone once complained to me saying “I would very much like to serve the Creator, blessed be He, and to cleave to the saints and listen to their words but I am very preoccupied with worldly affairs and because of this I have no one to advise me and I am far from the Creator of the world, blessed be His name.” And I replied to him that the Creator of the world, blessed be His name, is infinitely great and all worlds are but as a mustard seed next to Him—how then is it possible that this world and its empty and shameful preoccupations, which are but as a mustard seed, as mentioned, could stand and cover and conceal from his gaze such a great and awesome Creator? With saintly people, on the other hand, it is the opposite—and this is the true and proper way—they are constantly preoccupied with and engrossed in and attached to the luminosity of the Creator, blessed be He, and to His vitality that is in all things and in all places, as mentioned. They see nothing but Him and He covers and conceals this world from before their eyes.

Returning to our subject, the utterances of the Holy One, blessed be He, are within all objects, as it is written (Ps. 33:6) “By the word of the Lord were the heavens made, etcetera.” And these [utterances] are nothing but the names of the objects, such as [the Hebrew words for] bread and water and the like. These words comprise the vitality and taste and smell and appearance of each [object] and the vitality that is drawn down into each object is in accordance with their letters and permutations. And I already wrote a bit about this above, in [the section on] the periscope *Ki tisa* [commenting] on the verse (Est. 1:4) “when he showed the riches, etcetera.” Since everything was created and emanated from the vitality of God, blessed be His name, one must therefore elevate each thing to its root [and this is accomplished] when God’s holy people eat, drink and perform actions and deeds while cleaving to the Creator, blessed be He.

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ר' שלמה מלויצק, דברת שלמה (זאלקווא, תר"ח), ח"ב טו ע"א

לכאורה העוה"ז הוא הנראה לעינים והעולם הרוחני ותענוגיו אינו נראה כלל. אמנם באמת שהעיקר הנראה והנישיג הוא התענוג הרוחני כי כל מה שנראה ונישיג הוא רק המראה של כל דבר שנרא' שנשתנה לכמה גוונים או לבן או אדום וירוק וכיוצא ומצד הגשם אין שום חילוק כי הגשם הוא רק הכלי והגבלה שמגביל המראה והגוון אשר בו אבל מצד עצמו אינו כלום רק התענוג שבו שהוא המראה והגוון או מצד המישוש יש חילוק רך וקשה חם וקר וזה הכל דברים רוחניים וכן בטעמים יש בכ"א טעם בפ"ע טעמו של זה לא כטעמו של זה וכן בריח יש כמה וכמה שינוים והגשם של כל דבר הוא רק הכלי וההגבלה שמגביל המראה והטעם והריח והרוחנית הזוה הוא חיות הבורא ב"ה הנמשך ונגבל בגשמי' הזוה והן אותיותיו ודיבוריו הק' של הקב"ה כי האותיות הם רוחנים ומתוקי' ומוטעמים ומבושמים כמ"ש הנחמדים וכ' ומתוקים וכ' ואחז"ל כל דיבור כו' נתמלא בו העולם כולו בשמים כנ"ל וכן הם מפוארים כי הן כולם בהירות הבורא ב"ה וכתיב במראה אליו אתודע ואלו באתי לפרש הענין ולסדר הענין יותר איך ומה האותיות והדיבורי' הם רוחניים ומפוארי' בכל מיני גיוני' וריחנים וטעמים כפי מה שהבנתי וקבלתי מפי מורי זללה"ה כטפה מן הים תקצר הירי' מהכיל ואפי' להכניסם בדיבור ולהעלותם על הפה קשה הדבר וכמ"ש בזה"ק עד דלא יכול למלא ולזה צריך שקידה גדולה לשמש ת"ח וגדולי ישראל לשמוע דבריהם הנאמרי' באמת ומתוכם ילמוד להבין ולהשכיל ולהפשיט כ"ד מגשמיותו ולהסתכל רק ברוחניותו ויהי' תמיד חיות ובהירו' הבורא ית"ש לנגד עיניו ולא יראה זולתו כמ"ש שויתי ד' לנגדי תמיד וכמ"ש אין עוד מלבדו.

ופעם אחד בא אדם אחד בקובלנא לפני ואמר אני רוצה מאוד לעבוד הבורא ב"ה ולדבק בצדיקי' לשמוע דבריהם רק שאני מוטרד מאוד בעולם ובעסקיו ובגלל הדבר הזה אין אתי יודע עד מה ואני רחוק מהבורא עולם ית"ש. והשבתי לו הנה הבורא עולם ית"ש א"ס לגדלתו וכל העולמות בגרגור חרדל לפניו ואיך אפשר ויהיה זה שעה"ז ועסקיו הקטנים והנבזים שהם כגרגור חרדל כנ"ל יעמוד ויכסה ויעלים מלהסתכל אל הבורא הגדול והנורא הזה אמנם אצל אנשים צדיקים הוא ההיפך שהוא האמת והנכון שתמיד מוטרדי' ומושקעי' ומדובקי' בבהירות הבורא ב"ה ובחיותו שבכ"ד ובכ"מ כנ"ל ואינם רואים דבר זולתו והוא המכסה ומעלים את העוה"ז בפניהם

נחזור לעניננו שבכל דבר יש דיבורים של הקב"ה כמ"ש בדבר ד' שמים נעשו כו' והן הן השמות של כ"ד כגון לה"ם ומי"ם וכיוצ' והוא החיו' והטעם והריח והמרא' של כל דיבור לפי האותיות והצירופים של התיבות כך הוא המשכות החיות שבכ"ד וכבר כתבתי לעיל קצת בפ' כי תשא ע"פ בהראותו את עושר כו' כי כ"ד נברא ונאצל מחיותו ית"ש ולכן צריך שיתעלה הכל לשורשו ע"י אכילה ושתי' וע"י עשיות ועובדות של עם ד' הקדושים בדביקות הבורא ב"ה

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Or torah (Koretz, 1804), Pericope *Ki tisa* (unpaginated)

“For man shall not see Me and live” (Ex. 33:20). This refers to the four material elements in accordance with the mystery of man having been created from the earth. And understand. And these four elements lack the merit to behold the essential glory of God, the Holy One, blessed be He—only the spiritual elements concealed in the soul that [like the body] is similarly comprised of two hundred and forty eight limbs and three hundred and sixty five sinews that are spiritual [are able to behold it]. And [the soul] is “a portion of God from above” (Job 31:2) and is of the mystery of the living. This is the meaning of “and live”—only the living portion [of man] has this ability to behold the essential glory of God. And understand. Know, too, that the soul, in its perception (*hasagat ha-neshamah*) of the supernal spirituality, primarily apprehends (*maseget*) the aspect of desire (*heshek*) that inheres in the material object. And every instance of desire [arises] primarily by virtue of taste (*ta'am*). But taste is not tangible (*musag*) and anything that is not tangible is verily a portion of the Holy One, blessed be He. And this is the meaning of “He that sacrificeth unto the gods, save unto the Lord only, shall be utterly destroyed” (Ex. 22:19). “The gods” (*elohim*) is of the mystery of the external vessels [of the godhead], which are of the aspect of judgment. And every judgment is of the mystery of death and all death indicates materiality. And every material object is something tangible (*davar ha-musag*). And we are forbidden from sacrificing to and believing in materiality, in accordance with to the mystery of “Do not make to yourselves molten gods” (Lev. 19:4). And understand. We must instead believe in spirituality. This is [the meaning of] “save (*bilti*) unto the Lord”—this thing, which is not tangible (*bilti musag*), exists by virtue of the spiritual, which is verily “a portion of God from above.” This is [the meaning of] faith. And this is [the meaning of] “the Lord only”—without any [material] garment but solely the spiritual [aspect] itself. And this is the meanings of the verse (Ps. 91:14) “Because he hath set his desire upon (*vi*=within) Me”—the primary [element] of man’s worship [of God] is [his] desire, which is an aspect of the portion [of God] that is verily within him.

And this is [the meaning of] what is written in the *Tikunei zohar* (9a) “because upon me (*ki vi*)’ is numerically equivalent to forty-two,” which [refers to the forty-two letter divine name that] elevates all the worlds. And every [reference to] world (*olam*) is of the mystery of the aspect of [the divine attribute of] kingship (*malkhut*), which is called world. And it is [associated with] the letters *dalet yud nun* of the [divine] name Adonai (i.e. *din*=judgment) and we must elevate the judgments to the aspect of mercy and kindness which is [represented by] the [divine] name YHVH, blessed be He, which is [accomplished] only by means of the [divine] name of forty-two [letters]. And understand. And this is [the meaning of] “because he hath known My name” (Ps. 91:14)—[The Hebrew word for “My name” (*shemi*) is comprised of the word] “name” (*shem*) [and the letter] *yud* [which has a numerical value of ten]. One must elevate [the divine attribute of] kingship, which is called “name” and is the tenth *Sefirah*, so that she attains an elevated state (*ma’alah*). And every [instance of a] state [involves something] spiritual and everything spiritual is of the mystery of knowledge (*de’ah*). And this is [the meaning of] “because he hath known”—that is, you should elevate “My name,” which is [the attribute of] judgment, to the aspect of knowledge, which is spiritual. And understand.

We will explain the rest of the verses in passing. “I am with him in trouble” (Ps. 91:15)—in truth, I am [found] within all [material] garments. Even though all garments are of the mystery of trouble (*tzarah*) and trouble indicated materiality, which is judgment, I nevertheless rest therein in order to give it vitality. This is the meaning of “Out of my straits (*metzar*) I called upon the Lord” (Ps. 118:5). And understand. But if a person enflames himself with a great desire toward each and every letter—which are material and a garment—then he will merit that I will “remove” from every letter “the garments of her widowhood,” which “covered her face” (Gen. 38:14-5). For concealed within each and every letter there is spiritual vitality, referred to as “her face” (*paneha*), that is, [spiritual] inwardness (*penimiyut*). And you will [then] see that “she is righteous” (Gen. 38:26). And understand. This is [the meaning of] “I will rescue him (*ahaltzehu*)” (Ps. 91:15), as in “him that had his shoe loosed (*halutz*)” (Deut. 25:10)—that is, He will loose the black garments of every letter. “And I will bring him to honor” (Ps. 91:15)—I will show him spiritual letters, which are the glory of God. And if “long life” (Ps. 91:16) will be achieved from the aspect of the Infinite, [then] “I will satisfy him, and make him to behold My salvation” (Ps. 91:16)—he will merit to behold spirituality in itself. This is [the meaning of] “Show us Thy mercy, O Lord” (Ps. 85:8), which refers to the inwardness. “And grant us (*lanu*) Thy salvation” (Ps. 85:8)—[the word *lanu* is] numerically equivalent to [the word for] God (*Elohim*) [which represents judgments]—that she may be elevated. [And this is the meaning

of] “Our soul” (Ps. 33:20), referring to the external [aspect of the attribute of] kingship, “hath waited for the Lord (*la-ha-shem*)” (Ps. 33:20), to be elevated to the inwardness, which is [the meaning of] “to the Lord” (*la-ha-shem*).

The holy spirit (*ru'ah ha-kodesh*) has revealed to us that if there will come a time when a great desire arises among people to know God and to cleave to Him then this desire will be as acceptable as a burnt offering and as all of the [mystical] intentions. This is [the meaning of] “Because he hath set his desire upon Me”—for then the redemption will come, speedily in our days, amen. This is [the meaning of] “I will be with him in trouble”—even if they do not know any [mystical] intentions but are pained over this, wanting to attain apprehension [of God], and they serve Him with desire, then “I will rescue him” from the bitter exile “and make him to behold My salvation”—they will attain apprehension [of God] and “the earth shall be full of the knowledge [of the Lord]” (Isa. 11:9). And all of this [will come to pass] because of desire. This is [the meaning of] “For ye shall go out with joy” (Isa. 55:12). And understand.

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Elly Moseson, University of Hamburg

אור תורה (קארעץ, תקס"ד), פרש' כי תש

כי לא יראני האדם וחי. רומז לד' יסודות הגשמיים בסוד מן האדמה נברא האדם והבן ואלו הד' יסודות אין להם כח שיזכו לראות כבוד אלקים העצם הקב"ה. רק היסודות הרוחניים שהם כמוסים בנשמה, שהיא ג"כ רמ"ח איברים ושס"ה גידים רוחניים והיא חלק אלוה ממעל. והוא סוד ח"י וזהו וח"י ר"ל רק חלק חי יש לו כח זה לראות כבוד אלקים העצם והבן. ודע כי עיקר השגת הנשמה שהיא משגת רוחניות העליון הוא בחי' החשק שיש בדבר העשייה וכל חשק הוא עיקר מכח הטעם. וכל טעם הוא בלתי מושג. וכל דבר שהוא בלתי מושג הוא חלק ממש מהקב"ה. וזהו זובח לאלקים יחרם בלתי לה' לבדו. פ"י אלקים הוא סוד כלי החיצון שהוא דין וכל דין הוא סוד מיתה וכל מיתה רומז מגושם. וכל מגושם הוא דבר המושג. ואסור לנו לזבוח ולהאמין במגושם בסוד אלקי מסכ"ה לא תעשו לכם והבן. רק שצריכין אנו להאמין ברוחני וזהו בלתי לה' ר"ל דבר זה שהוא בלתי מושג הוא מכח הרוחניות שהוא ממש חלק אלוה ממעל. זה אמונה. וזהו לה' לבדו. בלי שום התלבשות, רק רוחני דרוחניות וזה פ"י הפסוק כי בי חשק, ר"ל עיקר העבודה של ב"א הוא החשק. שהוא בחי' החלק שיש בו ממש

וז"ש בתיקונים כ"י ב"י גי' מ"ב שהוא מעלה כל העולמות וכל עולם הוא סוד בחי' מלכות. שנקר' עולם והוא דין משם אדנ"י וצריכין אנו להעלות הדינים לבחי' רחמים וחסדים שהוא שם הוי"ה ב"ה. רק ע"י שם מ"ב והבן. וזהו כי ידע שמ"י ר"ל שם י' שיעלה מלכו' שהוא נקרא ש"ם, והיא ספירה עשירית ושתה' היא במעלה העליונה. וכל מעלה הוא רוחני. וכל רוחני הוא סוד דעה וזהו כי יד"ע ר"ל לבחי' דעה שהוא רוחני יעלה שמי שהוא דין והבן:

ואגב יפורש שאר הפסוק עמו אנכי בצרה ר"ל באמת בכל התלבשות שם אנכי. ואע"פ שכל התלבשות הוא סוד צרה וצרה רומז מגושם שהוא דין אעפ"כ אני שורה שם להחיות דבר זה. וזהו מן המיצר קראת י"ה והבן. אבל אם יתלהב האדם א"ע בחשק גדול לכל אות ואות שהוא גשמי והתלבשות אז יזכה שאסיר אני מכל אות בגדי אלמנותה שכסתה פניה כי בכל אות ואות מכוסה שם חיות רוחני שהוא פני' ר"ל פנימית ותראה שהיא צדקה והבן. וזהו ואחלצהו ל' חלוץ הנעל ר"ל שיחלוץ הלבוש השחור של כל אות ואכבדהו אני מראה לו אותיו' רוחני' שהם כבוד אלקים ואם ארך ימים מבחי' א"ס אשביעהו ואראהו בישועתי שיזכה לראות ברוחני ממש וזהו הראנו ה' חסדך הוא פנימ' וישעך תתן לנו גי' אלקים שיהיה לה עליי' נפשנו הוא מלכו' חיצונית חכתה לה' להיות לה עליי' לפנימיות וזהו לה':

ורוח הקודש גילה לנו אם יהיה זמן זה שיהי' חשק גדול לבני אדם לידע את השם ולדבק בו אז ירצה החשק הזה כעולה וככל הכוונות וזהו כי בי חשק ואז יהיה הגאולה בב"א. וזהו עמו אנכי בצרה. אע"פ שלא ידעו שום כוונה. רק שיהיה להם צער ע"ז להיות להם השגה ויעבד בחשק. אז אחלצהו מגלות המר ואראהו בישועתי שיהיה להם השגה ומלאה הארץ דעה והכל בשביל החשק. וזהו כי בשמחה תצאו והבן

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Likutim yekarim (Lemberg, 1792), 31a [Corrected on the basis of *Or ha-emet* (Husyatin, 1899), 73a]

There are two types of people—one who has love and fear [of God] on his own and another who does not have love and fear on his own. The solution [for this latter person] to arrive at the attribute of love is for him to do something for which he has great love, for example, consume excellent food and drink, [and he should consider that] the love he has for this food derives from the pleasure (*ta'anug*) that is clothed within it and pleasure is divine. By this means he will increase his love in the worship of God. I will record in passing a witticism I heard regarding [this]. It is known that the masses are accustomed to drink mead on Friday afternoon after going to the bath for the reason mentioned above, that is, so that they will have extra love during the afternoon and evening prayers since the prayers before the Sabbath require extra enthusiasm and great intention, even more so than all of the weekday prayers, as is known. But there are some people who drink so much that they become drunk (*she-shotin kol kah harbeh ad de-lo yada ve-khu[lu]*). And this [situation] is hinted at in the verse (Gen. 40:23) “Yet did not the chief cupbearer remember Joseph.” [The name Joseph] has the connotation of [increase, which suggests] the increase of sanctity on the Sabbath—that is, [the Kabbalistic concept of] the arousal of “the feminine waters” [i.e. the self-arousal] mentioned above, which is supposed to be accomplished through this [drinking]—“but he forgot him” (Gen. 40:23).

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ליקוטים יקרים (לעמבערג, תקנ"ב), לא ע"ב [בהשוואה לאור האמת (הוסיאטין, תרנ"ט), עג ע"א]

יש ב' כתות בני אדם יש אדם שיש לו ירא' ואהב' מצד עצמו ויש אדם שאין מתעורר מצד עצמו
[ל]אהב' או לירא' והתקנ' שלו שיבוא למדת האהב' שיעש' דבר שיש לו אהב' גדול' לזה למשל יאכל
וישתה דבר חשוב [ויחשוב] כי מה שיש לו אהב' לדבר המאכל ההוא הוא מחמת התענוג המלוכש
באותו מאכל והתענוג הוא אלהות ומחמת זה ניתוסף לו אהב' בעבודתו י"ת: ואגב זה אכתוב גם ההלצה
ששמעתי מענין [זה] כי ידוע שרוב המון עם מנהגם לשתות דבש בעש"ק אחר המרחץ והטעם הוא
כנ"ל כדי שיבוא להם אהב' יתיר' בתפילת המנח' ובערבית כי תפלת ערש"ק צריך התלהבות יתיר'
וכוונה גדול' יותר מכל תפילת החול כידוע אך יש בני אדם ששותין כ"כ הרבה על דלא ידע וכו' וזה
הרמז הפ' ולא זכר שר המשקים את יוסף הוא לשון תוספות קדושת שבת ר"ל העלאת המ"ן הנ"ל שיש
לו לעשות בזה [השתיה] וישכחהו: